

The Versatile Admiral:

Extra and Unconventional warfare rulesets for Cannons and Coastlines

By Joshua David

Welcome to the sea, where no man is safe, where no rule is unchangeable, and where drowning, taking enemy cannon fire, and running aground are occupational hazards. If you have opened this booklet, you are like me: a daring captain of an ever changing fleet on an ever-changing battlefield. We are the epitome of Deschamps' description: "a free people, born of the sea and of a brutal dream, without children and without old people, without homes and without churches, without hope but not without audacity, for whom atrocity is a career choice and death a certitude of the day after tomorrow." we change as frequently as the wind and as easily as the tide. This rulebook is a guide to my ideas and modifications. Use them, but be warned. Each offers a great advantage to their commander, but it is held in check by an equally great disadvantage. The bravest are prosperous, but also die the soonest. No fear! Make your choice! May the wind be ever at your back.

THE SALVORS

"Marine Salvage — A science of vague assumptions based on debatable figures taken from inconclusive experiments and performed with instruments of problematic accuracy by persons of doubtful reliability and questionable mentality."

The Salvors do not fight. They recover wrecks, restore them, and auction them back into play.

Two Salvor ships enter each game, controlled by a Salvor Captain.

SALVOR SHIPS

Indestructible

- Cannot be damaged, boarded, captured, or sunk
- Cannon fire and boarding have no effect
- Never lose fittings or become dead in the water
- Still block movement and line of fire

Movement

- Move Count: 4
 - May rotate up to 180° before moving
-

WRECKS

When a ship sinks:

- Leave its hull in place as a wreck
- Remove all fittings, sails, cannons, and flags
- Wrecks block movement and cannon fire
- Only Salvors may interact with wrecks

If a Salvor ship touches a wreck:

- Remove it from the table
 - Place it in the Salvor supply
-

RESTORATION

At the start of each Salvor turn:

- Restore 1 fitting to each recovered wreck

When all fittings are restored:

- The ship is fully repaired and ready for auction
-

AUCTION

Before moving each Salvor turn:

- Fully restored ships are auctioned

Rules:

- Starting bid: 1 coin
- Clockwise bidding
- Players may raise or pass
- Once passed, they may not re-enter
- Highest bidder pays the Salvors

Deployment:

- Place within 3" of buyer's table edge, or
- Touching a controlled island
- Ship may act on its owner's next turn

If no bids:

- The Salvors retain the vessel for future auction

SALVOR HOARD

- All coins paid to Salvors are placed in a separate Hoard
 - The Hoard is not part of the main coin bag
 - Coins in the Hoard cannot be drawn, stolen, or spent normally
-

SELLING FITTINGS

At the start of your turn, you may sell fittings to the Salvors:

For each fitting sold:

- gain 1 random coin from the Salvor Hoard
- Remove 1 fitting from one of your ships

Notes:

- This is voluntary damage to your ships
 - A ship reduced to 0 fittings becomes dead in the water
 - Any number of fittings may be sold per turn
-

SALVOR VICTORY

The Salvor Captain gains:

- 1 victory point per coin in the Salvor Hoard and win when they have 25 vps.

MERCENARIES

“Go tell the king of England– Go tell him thus from me– if he reigns king of all the land, then I reign king at sea.”

Mercenary ships are an unholy terror—fast, resilient, and devastating. They never join a fleet. They fight for the highest bidder.

One Mercenary ship enters the game, controlled at all times by the Mercenary Captain.

MERCENARY SHIP

Any ship can become a mercenary by adding these modified rules:

Elite Hull

- Ignores the first hit it takes each turn

Superior Crew

- Takes two actions each turn
- When it Fires, it may fire twice.

Fast Attack

- Move Count: 4
- May rotate up to 360° before moving

OPEN CONTRACT

At the start of each Mercenary turn, before acting:

- Any player may bid coins to direct the Mercenary ship against a target player

Rules:

- Minimum bid starts at 2 coins
- Bidding is open; each new bid must exceed the current highest
- All coins bid are paid to the Mercenary Captain
- The highest bidder names one target player

Escalation:

- Increase the minimum bid by +1 each turn the Mercenaries are hired
 - If no one bids, reset the minimum to 2
-

PROTECTION

Players may outbid attacks against themselves.

- Any number of players may contribute coins to a protection bid
- To negate an attack, the total must exceed the highest bid naming that player
- If successful, the Mercenaries must choose a different target or act freely

Mercenaries always follow the highest total payment.

MERCENARY ACTIONS

After bidding resolves:

- The Mercenary Captain controls the ship
- It takes two actions as normal

Targeting:

- If a target fleet was named, choose one of that fleet's ships within the Mercenary ship's Move distance at the start of its turn
 - Mercenaries may only attack that ship this turn
 - If no valid target is in range, the Mercenaries do nothing.
-

NO LOYALTY

- Mercenaries cannot be captured
 - They never capture islands
 - They are never part of any fleet
 - All agreements last one turn only
-

PAYMENT

- All coins paid go to the Mercenary Captain
-

MERCENARY VICTORY

The Mercenary Captain gains 1 VP per 2 coins collected and wins with 25 vps.

TOWABLE CANNON BARGES

Cannon Barges are fleet-built naval fortifications that begin as mobile platforms and can become permanent battlefield structures that define movement lanes, chokepoints, and territorial control.

Each fleet begins the game with one barge.

SETUP

- Each fleet starts with 1 Cannon Barge [use a book with an island topper puck on it]
-

CONTACT RULE

Ships may only physically touch a barge in the following cases:

1. While towing the barge
2. While performing an active attack or boarding action against it
3. During capture resolution (island rules)

At all other times, ships are not considered to be in contact with a barge.

If a resolving action would leave a ship illegally in contact, that contact ends immediately after resolution.

TOWING

Barges are mobile only while being towed.

To tow:

- A ship must initiate legal contact with the barge
- The ship uses its Move action to tow it

While towing:

- The ship moves normally but suffers -1 click movement (minimum 1)
 - The barge follows directly behind the ship
 - Contact persists only while towing
-

ACTIVE FIRING

While active, barges are mobile weapon platforms.

- Barges may fire all cannons normally
 - Cannons fire in fixed direction based on mount orientation
 - Barges do not require ship or flag contact to fire
-

DISABLED STATE

A barge becomes Disabled when all its fittings are removed.

Disabling is a transformation, not destruction.

PERMANENT STATE

A disabled barge becomes a permanent battlefield structure.

- Cannot be towed
- Cannot be repaired
- Cannot move
- Cannot be destroyed or removed

It remains on the table for the rest of the game.

FUNCTION

A disabled barge becomes a self-firing island structure.

- Fires all installed cannons each turn
 - Operates independently of ships or flag contact
 - Functions as a fixed strategic landmark shaping movement and control
-

CAPTURE

A disabled barge is treated as an island for all gameplay purposes.

Contact restriction:

Ships may only touch a disabled barge during:

- active attack resolution, or
- capture resolution

Resolution:

- Use standard island capture rules
- If capture succeeds, ownership changes immediately
- The barge remains disabled, immobile, and self-firing under the direction of the new owner.

SCHOOL ISLANDS

A special neutral island type that trains crews over time.

Setup

- Replace 1–2 standard islands with School Islands, or add them on top of the normal island count.
- Mark them clearly (different topper, color, or symbol).

Rules

- School Islands cannot be captured and never fly a flag.
- Any number of ships touching a School Island may take the Train action.

ACTION: TRAIN

If your ship is touching a School Island, it may take this action instead of Move, Fire, or Island:

- Place the ship on the School Island and mark it as In Training.
- The ship remains there for 10 of your turns.
- While In Training:
 - The ship cannot act, fire, or be targeted.
 - It does not block movement or island access.
 - It does not count as defending anything.
- Track turns with coins, markers, or by rotating the ship each turn.

At the end of the 10th turn, return the ship to play touching the island and choose one Skill.

SKILLS

- Sharpshooters
Once per turn, you may re-fire one missed shot immediately.
 - Veteran Crew
This ship can take one extra 45° rotation before or after its normal Move.
 - Reinforced Hull
This ship gains +1 extra hit before becoming Dead in the Water.
 - Rapid Reload
Once per turn, this ship may fire twice without spending Skilled Gunner.
 - Boarding Specialists
Boarding Party removes 2 fittings instead of 1 (still costs 1 coin).
 - Signal Experts
When this ship uses Signal Flags, it may affect two ships instead of one.
-

FORCED RECALL

If all your other ships are sunk, any ship In Training must:

- Immediately return to play at the School Island edge
- Skip its next action

THE MINELAYER

A unique support ship that controls the battlefield with proximity mines. It cannot fight on its own and must operate through alliance.

FACTION RULES

There is only one Minelayer ship in play, and it can be sunk.

For mines, use any small object, preferably brightly colored, under 2" in diameter.

The Minelayer cannot take the Fire action and has no functional cannon use.

At the start of the game, the Minelayer must form an alliance with at least one other player. It cannot act independently. If it has no ally at the beginning, it cannot take actions.

The Minelayer and its allies may coordinate freely, but remain separate for scoring unless using Fleet rules.

MINE NETWORK

The Minelayer may have up to 10 mines total on the table at any time.

This limit applies globally to the Minelayer, not per player.

LAY MINE

The Minelayer may take this action instead of Move:

Place one mine touching the ship's stern.

Mines cannot overlap ships, islands, terrain, or other mines. Once placed, they remain until destroyed.

Newly placed mines do not trigger until the start of the Minelayer's next turn.

PROXIMITY TRIGGER

A mine detonates when any ship comes within 2" of it at any time during movement or repositioning.

When triggered:

- The ship is immediately scuttled and removed from play
- No fittings are removed
- The mine is also removed

RULE INTERACTIONS

Mines:

- Ignore all defensive effects
- Affect all ships, including allied ships, but not the minelayer.
- Only trigger on ships (not terrain or islands)

A ship destroyed by a mine is removed immediately and takes no further actions.

CLEARING MINES

mines may only be removed by Cannon fire, which destroys the mine on direct hit

PLACEMENT LIMITS

- Mines must be at least 2" apart
- Mines cannot be placed:
 - Touching islands
 - Within 2" of a table edge

If placing a mine would exceed the 10 mine limit, remove one existing mine first.

ALLIANCE RULES

The Minelayer must maintain at least one ally at all times.

- If all allies are eliminated, the Minelayer may continue to take actions until a new alliance is formed
- Alliances may shift during play using standard alliance rules.